

Episode 191: *Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes – Part 18

The newly redesigned Web Anime Style. One day Oguro-san said "We'd like to add a cover illustration to this column." "Hmm, should I draw pictures like other writers? Ah, but that's somehow different for me (laugh)." So I thought about it a bit and submitted a rough idea saying "How about something like this?" The designer skillfully put it together into that cover illustration.

The colour chart-style design used in the background is actually a real colour chart (laugh). Since we can't make colour models for all colouring specifications (like dust cloud colour specifications or minor prop colour specifications), we use colour charts like this for colour direction input. This chart is one I made myself, and I use it for almost all works where I'm in charge of design. I add modifications each time to match the work's content and colour tone tendencies.

Making colour charts is quite fun, but once you start, it takes an incredible amount of time. It's fun and you forget time passing and get absorbed, to the point where it interferes with other work (laugh). So it's troublesome because I sometimes want to play with colour charts as a form of escapism (laugh).

Now then.

Episode 15: The One Who Saves the World Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiko & Shibata Katsunori, Direction/Shibata Katsunori, Colour Direction/Mizuno Taeko (水野多恵子)

Ringo, caught in Yuri's trap, about to have this and that and even such things done to her. But then, unexpectedly Shoma appears! Not exactly dashing - he trips, hits his head, and faints. Yuri is somewhat exasperated, but her thoughts turn to her young days, meeting Momoka, and the days they spent together. And aiming for the other half of the diary that such a Yuri possesses, Masako had infiltrated the inn. Such was Episode 15.

Actually, Episode 15 was the important episode that tells the core of Momoka's mystery. Momoka appearing in Yuri's childhood dominated by her father's twisted affection. And Yuri's flashback story of being liberated by Momoka's "ability." The first surprise of such Episode 15 was the "David Statue Tower" (laugh).

This David Statue Tower was originally made with 3DCG. We also bought a ready-made David statue 3D model, output it to background rough drawings according to layout, and since using the 3D model as-is would float too much on screen, we had art add retouching and photography blend it in. But initially this didn't go well and was quite difficult. What was difficult was expressing that size and building-like feeling. This "David Statue Tower" is about Tokyo Tower height in the story, but just normally placing it on background and blending it didn't quite convey the sense of a gigantic building.

Well, it's a David statue after all. If this moved around like in robot shows, size expression would be easy, but this is a tower and building so it doesn't move, and it shouldn't move (laugh). If that building-like quality doesn't come out naturally, the screen lacks persuasiveness. We tried flying helicopters from the tower's back to front, but somehow it didn't work well.

For example, using many cuts to finely depict the statue's surface details in close-up, looking up from the feet with upward angle layouts, properly showing comparisons with something - if we piled up several such cuts we could certainly express height, size, and building-like texture, but there's no need to single out this tower and deliberately show it by layering cuts like that. We just wanted it to be there naturally in the landscape, casually without discomfort (laugh).

So at some meeting attempt, I suddenly thought "How about adding 'windows' like observation decks?" Buildings are indeed about windows. This conveyed the size of space where people exist inside the tower, so both size and building feeling were perfect. The texture as an artificial structure tower was established.

Incidentally, the new tower (Tokyo Tower) brought by "fate transfer" also uses a 3D model.

So from that opening with the David Statue Tower surprise in the past flashback, another surprise was, well, that father (laugh). For all atelier scenes I thought to create a slight sense of unreality, having photography apply strong diffusion to characters and strongly create a colour bleeding feeling. Particularly in the opening evening atelier scene, against the yellow-toned western sunlight background, I applied pink~purple shadow colours to characters to create a mad atmosphere. I wanted to properly make an impression of this father's madness here, and I think we successfully created it.

On the other hand, scenes with Momoka rather built up quiet colour usage matter-of-factly matching spatial brightness. Particularly the scene telling of the diary and "fate transfer" under the afterglow after sunset, combined with that quiet, repetitive, shuddering music, is personally a quietly favourite scene of mine.

Oh yes, in the world with the David Statue Tower, in flashback scenes there are no Ping marks throughout the city. Not limited to this episode's flashback, in characters' distant past flashbacks it's like that. Did you notice?

Now, in the actual timeline it's the hospital and hot spring inn.

For the hot spring inn, the dark room tones of Yuri and Ringo's room - I created three types divided by scene content. The first half aimed for that mysterious atmosphere with purple-like colour tones, and after Shoma bursts in I created more normal-like colour tones to strengthen reality feeling. In the scene with Masako dressed as an inn attendant, I created atmosphere with blue-toned colours to match the expression of quietly listening to Masako's story in the sliding door shadows, and in the scene where Shoma wakes up after everything ends, I deliberately made it brighter with normal colour tone balance to create a relieved feeling of conclusion. Except for the initial mysterious atmosphere scene, the background art brightness and colour tone are basically the same,

but I created these impressions through differences in character colour tones. Creating colours, this kind of thing is fun (laugh).

I forgot to write this last time, but there's a convenience store bag casually placed in front of the safe in the inn guest room. When I asked Director Yamazaki "What's this?" she said "Ah, that's an 'overnight set.' Ringo bought it!" Ah, I see! This is truly the perspective of a female director, I thought!

Now clearly revealed this time are Momoka's diary secrets, but here's another secret revelation! The pages where Momoka's diary is written were actually production assistant Kagaya's responsibility. Following text content created by Director Ikuhara and Assistant Director Yamazaki, Kagaya handwrote it. All the illustrations are also Kagaya's hand-drawn work (laugh). We had him quickly write things during busy intervals, then had photography paste them in as-is.

So for this diary, we thought up content for only the pages needed for main story scenes each time and had Kagaya write them each time. Occasionally when other pages were unexpectedly needed on screen, we'd frantically think up text and order from Kagaya - this happened many times (laugh). Since we were making the diary in such an ad-hoc way (!), we didn't have text & illustrations for a full diary volume. Ah, thinking about it now, if we had properly made a full volume, we could have sold it as merchandise (laugh). There were surely many people who would have wanted it!

Even so, Yamashita-kun is mysterious. Why did he invite Shoma to the hot springs? Mysterious, right? Suspicious, right.

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